

HARVESTING

Lettuces with hearts take longer to mature than the loose-leaf varieties, but all lettuces are fairly quick to grow and can be harvested at the baby stage in as little as five weeks. When harvesting, make sure to cut the heading lettuces as soon as they are mature; otherwise, you run the risk that they will rot in wet conditions or bolt in hot or dry conditions.

You can harvest loose-leaf lettuces to use whole, or use them as cut-and-come-again crops. Remove the outer leaves as you need them and leave the inner ones to continue growing. Or, if cutting the entire lettuce, use scissors and cut away the leaves, leaving around 1 in (2.5 cm) of the plant in the ground.

Lettuce stumps regrow and may provide you with a second crop of leaves—continue to care for them as usual and in a couple of weeks the new leaves will resprout.

STORING

Lettuce can be kept for a little while in a sealed plastic bag in the refrigerator, but it is best eaten as fresh as possible. Try to harvest only as much as you need at any given time, to prevent spoilage and waste.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Lettuces are susceptible to these pests and diseases in particular, so guard against them wherever possible.

- Slugs and snails love tender young leaves and may munch their way into the hearts of larger lettuces. Use pellets, or create a barrier to crops using a cloche.
- Cutworms, leatherjackets, and wireworms attack the roots of lettuces, causing them to wilt.
- Lettuce root aphids can be a big problem. They feed on lettuce roots, causing the plant to wilt. Remove Lombardy poplars, the pest's other host. Or grow resistant varieties.
- Botrytis—or gray mold—might strike lettuces if weather is wet. Fluffy gray mold will appear on the leaves and can destroy the entire plant.



Slugs (left) can devastate an entire row of vulnerable lettuce seedlings. **Use a line of grit or sand (right)** to keep slugs or snails away from seedlings.